

Music for choirs

Choirs typically sing in four parts—soprano, alto, tenor, and bass—known as SATB. Learning to write in four parts is excellent training in composition because each part has to have its own direction and interest.

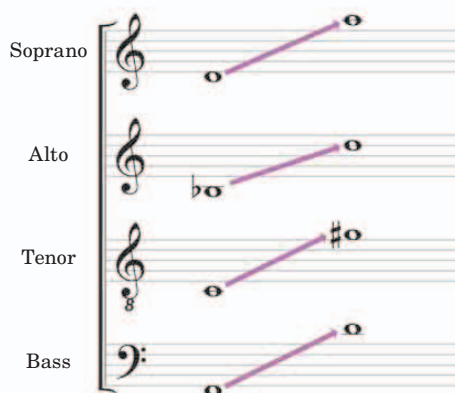
SEE ALSO

- ◀ 14–15 High and low
- ◀ 18–19 Notes on the staff
- ◀ 126–127 Triads

Voices 192–193 >

Ranges

Each person's voice has its own range, but for the sake of practicality in both composition and performance, music for choirs tends to work within set boundaries for each voice. Note that the 8 below the treble staff indicates that the tenor part sounds an octave below the notated pitch.



- ◁ **Soprano** 127
The soprano range typically spans from the D above Middle C to a top A.
- ◁ **Alto** 128
Alto ranges from B below Middle C to D in the treble staff.
- ◁ **Tenor** 129
The range from C to the G above Middle C is tenor.
- ◁ **Bass** 130
The bass part ranges from a bottom F to the D above Middle C.

Closed score

A closed score indicates that the music is laid out on two staves with a treble and bass clef. The layout of the tenor part helps differentiate between open and closed scores. A tenor part in an open score with four staves has to be transcribed from treble to bass clef.



▽ "Jesu, Joy of Man's Desiring"

On the treble staff, the soprano part is written at the top with the stems upward; the alto part is beneath it with stems pointing downward. On the bass staff, the tenor is at the top and the bass part is beneath it.

Voice leading

Voice leading describes how a part moves from one note to the next.



△ **Contrary motion**
In contrary motion, the parts move in opposite directions.



△ **Oblique motion**
Here, one part remains on the same note, while the other moves up or down.



△ **Similar motion**
In similar motion, both the parts move in the same direction.



△ **Parallel motion**
Here, both the parts move up or down by the same interval.